Blog

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STEM VS. HUMANITIES: CHOOSING YOUR DEGREE PATH

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EXPLORE CATEGORIES

For most students, choosing a college major is a pivotal life decision, shaping not only their career trajectory but also their approach to problem-solving for years to come.

The STEM versus humanities degrees debate has intensified as technology has reshaped the job market, leaving many students wondering which path offers them better prospects.

Learning about the variety of degree programs available can help individuals decide which path is best for them to pursue to achieve their personal and professional goals.

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WHAT IS A STEM DEGREE?

STEM stands for science, technology, engineering and mathematics — fields that emphasize qualitative analysis, systematic experimentation and technical problem-solving.

Popular STEM degree majors include:

- Biology
- Chemistry
- Physics
- Engineering
- Data science
- Mathematics

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STEM degree programs have gained significant attention due to workforce demands in the overlapping sectors of technology, healthcare and engineering. Jobs in these sectors often require specialized technical knowledge that STEM students progressively build as they advance along their academic and early professional journey.

WHAT IS A HUMANITIES DEGREE?

Humanities encompasses the critical study of human culture, thought, expression and values throughout history and across societies.

Popular humanities degree majors include:

- History
- Philosophy
- Art history
- Literature
- Education
- Criminal justice
- Law
- Communication
- Foreign languages
- Anthropology

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culture, morality, history and humanity. Humanities degree programs also allow students to explore technology tools through an interdisciplinary lens.

While STEM careers have been in the spotlight in recent years, employers are increasingly valuing skills developed in humanities degree programs, as these skills help professionals adapt to the impacts of artificial intelligence (AI) and other emerging technologies. The most in-demand skills among employers in 2024, according to LinkedIn, included durable skills such as communication, customer service, leadership, research and problem-solving.

STEM VS. HUMANITIES DEGREES: WHAT ARE THE DIFFERENCES?

In a comparison of STEM versus humanities degrees, the differences tend to lie in their methodology and focus.

METHODS AND LEARNING APPROACH

STEM disciplines rely on empirical observation, quantitative analysis and systematic testing to understand the natural world. STEM programs emphasize hands-on experimentation, mathematical problem-solving and technical skill development.

Humanities disciplines use qualitative analysis, interpretation and critical examination to understand human culture and experience. Humanities programs focus on developing critical reading, writing and discussion skills, often with an emphasis on deep understanding, flexible thinking and a keen attention to detail when analyzing complex social and cultural issues.

CAREER PREPARATION

STEM degree programs can prepare students for many specific technical roles, such as software developer, engineer, research scientist or data analyst.

Humanities degree programs prepare students for careers by enabling them to develop and hone transferable skills that are applicable across various fields, from law to policy writing, journalism, business and education.

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Humanities students can cultivate effective communication skills, cultural competency, ethical reasoning and skills involved in synthesizing and evaluating complex information from multiple sources.

JOB MARKET DYNAMICS

The U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) defines STEM occupations as architecture and engineering, life and physical sciences, mathematics and computer occupations. STEM occupations are expected to see strong job growth in the coming years, according to the BLS, with projected employment increases of 8.1 percent between 2024 and 2034, creating more than 870,000 jobs. Additionally, the 2024 median annual wage for professionals in STEM occupations was $103,580, according to the BLS.

Specific high-growth occupations within STEM include the following:

Information security analyst: 29 percent growth, $124,910 median salary

Actuaries: 22 percent growth, $125,770 median salary

Computer and information research scientists: 20 percent growth, $140,910 median salary

Forensic science technicians: 13 percent growth, $67,440 median salary

Industrial engineers: 11 percent growth, $101,140 median salary

Humanities occupations are also seeing rising demand in the changing job market due to the need for professionals with strong communication and critical thinking skills. According to a 2025 report from the American Academy of Arts and Sciences, about 95 percent of humanities bachelor's degree holders were fully employed and had a median salary of $64,000, while nearly 97 percent of those with an advanced humanities degree were fully employed with a median salary of $87,000.

Specific humanities occupations with strong employment outcomes, according to the BLS, include the following:

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Anthropologists and archeologists: 4 percent growth, $64,910 median salary

Police and detectives: 3 percent growth, $77,270 median salary

WHY STUDENTS CHOOSE STEM OR HUMANITIES DEGREES

Students gravitate toward STEM degrees for several compelling reasons. Financial considerations play a significant role, as STEM occupations often offer higher starting salaries and stronger job security than other occupations. Also, the technology sector's rapid growth creates abundant opportunities for skilled professionals. Many students find satisfaction in solving concrete problems and seeing tangible results from their work as well.

STEM degree programs appeal to students who enjoy logical thinking, working with data and learning how things function. STEM degree programs offer clear metrics for success and opportunities to contribute to technological advancement and scientific discovery.

Humanities degrees attract students passionate about understanding human nature, culture and society. These students often value intellectual exploration, creative expression and meaningful dialogue about life's big questions. They're drawn to careers that involve helping others, preserving culture or influencing social change. Humanities graduates often demonstrate a high level of career flexibility and are qualified to advance into leadership roles that require strong communication and critical thinking skills.

Many humanities students appreciate their degree program's emphasis on developing well-rounded thinking and communication abilities. They recognize that understanding human behavior, cultural dynamics and ethical considerations is increasingly valuable in our interconnected world.

CHOOSE SEMO ONLINE FOR YOUR DEGREE

Individuals considering STEM versus humanities for a career shouldn't necessarily view the two choices as mutually exclusive. Many successful professionals combine both approaches — bioethicists blend science with philosophy, technical writers merge engineering knowledge with communication skills and digital humanities scholars use technology to analyze cultural phenomena.

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Recommended Readings:
Computer Science vs. AI: How the Fields Fit Together
How to Become a Teacher in Missouri
Applied Technology Degree Job Options

Sources:
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American Philosophical Association Blog, "The STEM/Humanities Divide and Student Defeatism"
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University World News, "Keeping the Humanities Out of Science May Be Bad for Science"
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U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Employment in STEM Occupations
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U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Forensic Science Technicians
U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Industrial Engineers
U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Lawyers
U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Police and Detectives
U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Social Workers
U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Writers and Authors
Viveve, "11 Top Jobs in Humanities and Their Salaries"

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LOCATION

One University Plaza
Cape Girardeau, MO 63701

CONTACT

(573) 651-2000

Contact Us

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